

Lionel Andrés "Leo" Messi^[note 1] (Spanish pronunciation: [ljoˈnel anˈdɾes ˈmesi] ⓘ; born 24 June 1987) is an Argentine professional footballer who plays as a forward for and captains both Major League Soccer club Inter Miami and the Argentina national team. Widely regarded as one of the greatest players of all time, Messi set numerous records for individual honors won throughout his professional footballing career: eight Ballon d'Or awards, six European Golden Shoes, and eight times being named the world's best player by FIFA.^[note 2] He is the most decorated player in the history of professional football with 44 team trophies,^[note 3] including twelve league titles, four UEFA Champions Leagues, two Copa Américas, and one FIFA World Cup. Messi holds the records for most goals for a single club (672, with Barcelona), most goals (474), hat-tricks (36) and assists (192) in La Liga, most matches played (39), assists (18) and goal contributions (34) in the Copa América, most matches played (26) and goal contributions (21) in the World Cup, most international appearances (187) and international goals (109) by a South American male, and the second-most in the latter category outright. A prolific goalscorer and creative playmaker, Messi has scored over 800 senior career goals for club and country. Born in Rosario, Santa Fe in Argentina, Messi relocated to Spain to join Barcelona at age 13, and made his competitive debut at age 17 in October 2004. He established himself as an integral player for the club within the next three years, and in his first uninterrupted season in 2008–09 helped Barcelona achieve the first treble in Spanish football; that year, aged 22, Messi won his first Ballon d'Or. Messi won four consecutive Ballons d'Or, the first player to win it four times. During the 2011–12 season, he set La Liga and European records for most goals in a season, while establishing himself as Barcelona's all-time top scorer. The following two seasons, he finished second for the Ballon d'Or behind Cristiano Ronaldo, his perceived career rival, before regaining his best form during the 2014–15 campaign, where he became the all-time top scorer in La Liga and led Barcelona to a historic second treble, resulting in a fifth Ballon d'Or in 2015. Messi assumed captaincy of Barcelona in 2018, and won a record sixth Ballon d'Or in 2019. During his overall tenure at Barcelona, Messi won a club-record 34 trophies: ten La Liga titles, seven Copa del Reys, four UEFA Champions Leagues, seven Supercopa de Españas, three UEFA Super Cups, and three FIFA Club World Cups. He signed for French club Paris Saint-Germain in August 2021, winning two Ligue 1 titles and one Trophée des Champions during both of his seasons there. Messi joined American club Inter Miami in July 2023, winning the Leagues Cup in August. An Argentine international, Messi is the national team's all-time leading goalscorer and most-capped player. His style of play as a diminutive, left-footed dribbler drew comparisons with compatriot Diego Maradona, who described Messi as his successor. At youth level, he won the 2005 FIFA World Youth Championship and gold medal at the 2008 Summer Olympics. After his senior debut in 2005, Messi became the youngest Argentine to play and score in a World Cup (2006). He assumed the national team's captaincy in 2011, and then led Argentina to three consecutive finals: the 2014 FIFA World Cup, the 2015 Copa América and the Copa América Centenario, all of which they would lose. After initially announcing his international retirement in 2016, he returned to help his country narrowly qualify for the 2018 FIFA World Cup, which they would again exit early. Messi and the national team would finally break Argentina's 28-year trophy drought with a victory in the 2021 Copa América, which helped Messi win his seventh Ballon d'Or later that year. He then led Argentina to win the 2022 FIFA World Cup, where he was awarded a record second Golden Ball after scoring seven goals including two in the final. He would receive a record-extending eighth Ballon d'Or in 2023. A second Copa América victory with Messi as captain followed in 2024. Messi has endorsed sportswear company Adidas since 2006. According to France

Football, he was the world's highest-paid footballer for five years out of six between 2009 and 2014, and was ranked the world's highest-paid athlete by Forbes in 2019 and 2022. Messi was among Time's 100 most influential people in the world in 2011, 2012, and 2023. In 2020 and 2023, he was named the Laureus World Sportsman of the Year, the first team-sport athlete to win it. In 2020, Messi was named to the Ballon d'Or Dream Team and became the second footballer and second team-sport athlete to surpass \$1 billion in career earnings. In 2024, Messi founded Más+.